

Braselton Sermon Notes

Title

Two Men, One Gospel: Demas, Luke, and the Question of First Love

Occasion

Braselton Seventh-day Adventist Church Target length: 30 minutes Primary tone: pastoral, searching, steady, hopeful

Core burden

Demas and Luke stood near the same apostle, heard the same gospel, and lived in the same difficult hour. One drifted. One remained. The difference was not intelligence, gifting, or opportunity. The difference was love. Demas loved "this present world." Luke stayed near Christ, and so stayed near Paul.

Main thesis

The deepest spiritual danger is not always open rebellion. Sometimes it is faithful-looking activity with a cooling heart. Demas warns us that a person can remain near the work while drifting from Christ. Luke shows us that steadfast love is possible, even in a costly age.

Main texts

- 2 Timothy 4:9-11
- Colossians 4:14
- Philemon 1:23-24
- Revelation 2:1-5
- Luke 9:23

Supporting texts

- 1 John 2:15-17
- Matthew 6:21
- John 21:15-17
- Philippians 3:7-8
- Hebrews 12:1-3
- Exodus 20:8-11
- Isaiah 58:13-14

One-sentence sermon frame

Demas did not leave the work first. He left his love first.

Quotable lines

- A person can remain near ministry while drifting from Christ.
- The most dangerous spiritual condition is not rebellion, but religious motion with misplaced affection.
- Demas did not collapse in a moment. He drifted by degrees.
- Luke was not merely in the room with Paul. He was anchored in Christ.
- The Sabbath is God's weekly resistance against becoming Demas.
- You do not have to leave the church to leave your first love.

Thirty-minute flow

1. Opening scene - Paul's last attendance list (4 minutes)

Read 2 Timothy 4:9-11 slowly.

Suggested opening:

Paul is in his final imprisonment. The letter is short, urgent, and heavy with the nearness of death. Then he begins naming names. One line breaks the heart: "Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world." A second line steadies the room: "Only Luke is with me."

Pastoral move:

Tell the congregation this is not mainly a sermon about a bad man and a good man. It is a sermon about the direction of the heart under pressure.

2. The tragedy of Demas - same start, different finish (7 minutes)

Walk the three Demas texts in order:

- Colossians 4:14 - Demas is present.
- Philemon 1:24 - Demas is called a fellow laborer.
- 2 Timothy 4:10 - Demas has forsaken Paul, loving this present world.

Key interpretive point:

Paul does not emphasize scandal, only affection. Demas loved the present age. The drift was internal before it became visible.

Medical illustration:

There is a difference between an acute collapse and a chronic disease. One alarms the room immediately. The other progresses quietly until the patient is weaker than anyone realized. Demas is the chronic disease of misplaced love.

Braselton application:

Some of us are not being pulled toward obvious wickedness. We are being pulled toward comfort, advancement, recognition, security, and self-protection. Good things can become ruling things.

3. The faithfulness of Luke - the quiet strength of a steady disciple (6 minutes)

Texts:

- Colossians 4:14 - "Luke, the beloved physician"
- 2 Timothy 4:11 - "Only Luke is with me"

Development:

Luke had skills, status, and options. Yet when pressure intensified, he did not disappear into a safer life. He stayed with Paul because he had already settled the deeper question of devotion.

Tie Luke's Gospel to Luke's life:

- Luke recorded, "If any man will come after me, let him deny himself..." (Luke 9:23).
- Luke did not merely preserve the words of costly discipleship. He embodied them.

Line to land:

Luke wrote about following Jesus, then followed Him when it became expensive.

4. The wider diagnosis - Ephesus and first love (6 minutes)

Read Revelation 2:2-5.

Show the contrast:

Ephesus had labor, doctrine, patience, endurance, and discernment. Yet Christ said, "Thou hast left thy first love."

Pastoral emphasis:

This means spiritual danger can exist inside orthodoxy, duty, and church activity. A congregation can be busy and cooling at the same time. An elder, deacon, parent, young adult, physician, professional, musician, or preacher can be serving and drifting simultaneously.

Bridge sentence:

Demas is what Revelation 2 looks like in a single biography.

5. The Adventist corrective - Sabbath and reordered affection (4 minutes)

This is where the sermon becomes distinctly Adventist without becoming merely denominational.

Main idea:

The Sabbath is not only about stopping labor. It is about refusing false saviors. It interrupts the lie that worth is produced by achievement. It restores relationship over performance.

Use:

- Exodus 20:8-11
- Isaiah 58:13-14

Line to use:

The Sabbath is God's built-in resistance against becoming Demas.

Explain carefully:

Not a rule to burden us, but a rescue to reorder us.

6. Appeal - remember, repent, return (3 minutes)

Use Revelation 2:5:

- Remember
- Repent
- Do the first works

Appeal questions:

- What is competing with Christ for your deepest affection right now?
- What good thing has moved too close to the center?
- If someone wrote one sentence about your spiritual life five years from now, would it sound more like Colossians 4 or 2 Timothy 4?

Closing line:

Luke stayed. Not because the age was easy, but because Christ was worth more.

Ellen G. White placements

Quote placement 1 - Demas

Use after Point 2.

Reference:

Acts of the Apostles, p. 455.2

Use:

She says Demas was steadfast for a time, then forsook the cause of Christ, and for worldly gain bartered high and noble considerations. This sharpens the idea of tragic exchange.

Quote placement 2 - Luke

Use in Point 3.

Reference:

Acts of the Apostles, p. 490.2

Use:

She notes that "Only Luke is with me," and that Luke's services were a great comfort to Paul. This lets you present Luke not as flashy, but as present.

Quote placement 3 - Ephesus losing first love

Use in Point 4.

Reference:

Acts of the Apostles, pp. 547-548, and 578-579

Use:

She describes believers becoming more strict in outward forms while losing sight of the Saviour and His love. This is exactly the danger your sermon is naming.

Quote placement 4 - love as the engine of obedience

Use in appeal or near the Sabbath section.

Reference:

Steps to Christ, p. 59.2

Use:

When Christ's love rules the heart, duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure.

Quote placement 5 - devotion crowded out by busyness

Use in the Demas section or transition to application.

Reference:

Testimonies for the Church, vol. 5, p. 161

Use:

Ellen White warns that hurried prayer and no real communion with God reveal an inner problem. This helps you diagnose drift without sounding harsh.

Delivery guidance

Tone

- Begin reflective, not loud.
- Avoid making Demas the villain too early.
- Let Luke feel beautiful because he is steady, not dramatic.
- Let the appeal feel like invitation, not accusation.

Where to slow down

- After reading 2 Timothy 4:10
- After saying "Demas did not leave the work first. He left his love first."
- After reading Revelation 2:4
- Before the final appeal questions

Where to personalize

You can briefly say that in a demanding professional life it is possible to confuse meaningful work with spiritual health. That line will carry special credibility coming from you.

Suggested sentence:

In a busy life, it is dangerously easy to mistake productivity for devotion. The calendar looks full, the outcomes look respectable, and the soul has quietly gone thin.

What to cut first if time runs short

- Shorten the medical illustration in Point 2
- Reduce supporting texts in Point 4
- Keep the Luke section, but cut one example
- Do not cut the final appeal

Optional opening prayer emphasis

Lord, search not only what we do, but what we love. Do not merely correct our schedule. Reorder our hearts. In Jesus' name, amen.

Optional closing prayer emphasis

Lord, save us from serving You with wandering hearts. Rekindle first love. Teach us to stay. Make us more like Luke than Demas. In Jesus' name, amen.

Optional hymn ideas

- "I Would Draw Nearer to Jesus"
- "Take the World, but Give Me Jesus"
- "Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus"
- "I Surrender All"